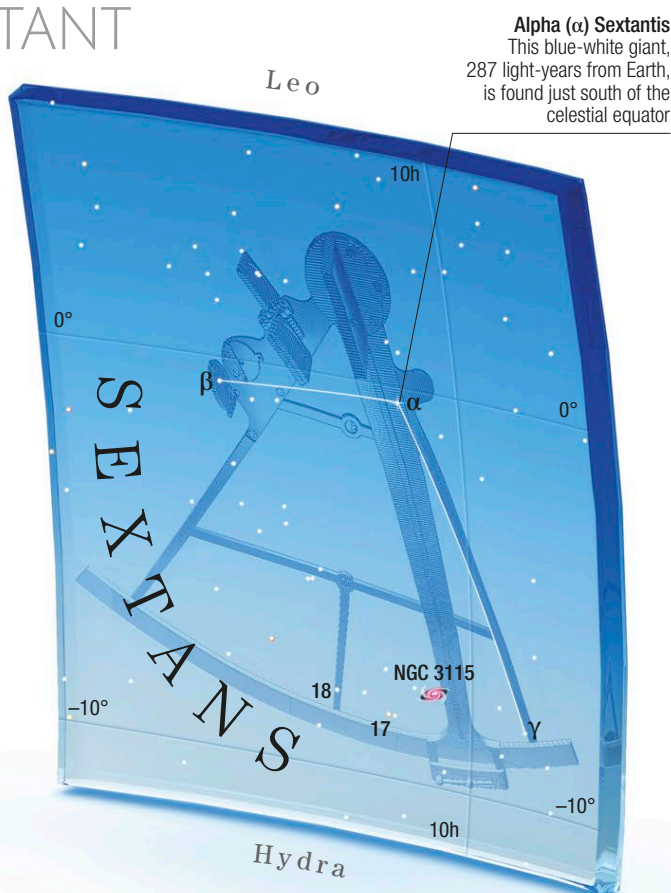


SEXTANS THE SEXTANT

THIS FAINT CONSTELLATION LIES DIRECTLY ON THE CELESTIAL EQUATOR. IT CAN BE FOUND CLOSE TO THE STAR REGULUS IN LEO.

Just three stars define the Sextant, a constellation identified by the Polish astronomer Johannes Hevelius in 1687. It represents an instrument used on board ship for position-finding. Sextans' stars are relatively dim, its brightest being only magnitude 4.5, and none are named. Its galaxies are best viewed through large telescopes. NGC 3115, called the Spindle Galaxy because it appears spindle-shaped in the sky, is magnitude 8.5 and just visible through binoculars in good conditions. Two unrelated stars of 6th magnitude, 17 and 18 Sextantis are close by and also only visible through binoculars.



Alpha (α) Sextantis
This blue-white giant, 287 light-years from Earth, is found just south of the celestial equator

KEY DATA

Size ranking	47
Brightest stars	Alpha (α) 4.5, Gamma (γ) 5.1
Genitive	Sextantis
Abbreviation	Sex
Highest in sky at 10pm	March–April
Fully visible	78°N–83°S



CHART 5



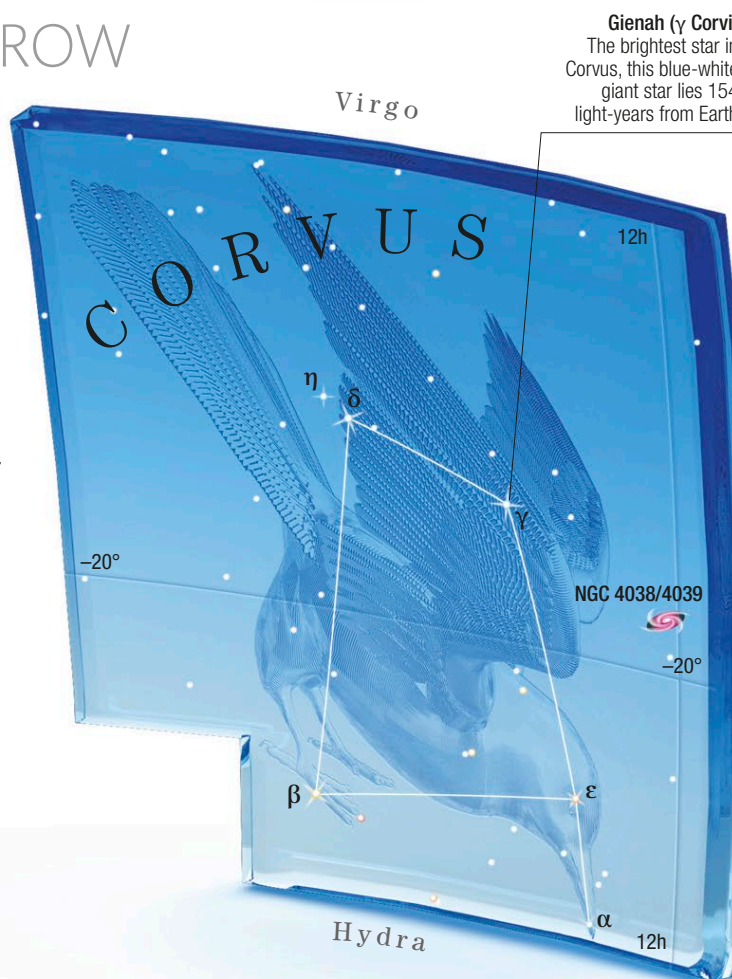
△ NGC 3115

This huge lenticular galaxy is seen edge-on from Earth. Its central bulge of stars is clearly visible. A supermassive black hole is hidden from view, deep inside. Also known as the Spindle Galaxy, the galaxy is about 30 million light-years away. It is not to be confused with the Spindle Galaxy in Draco.

CORVUS THE CROW

THIS CONSTELLATION'S SHAPE IS DEFINED BY ITS FOUR BRIGHTEST STARS, WHICH FORM THE BODY OF THE CROW.

Corvus is the sacred bird of the Greek god Apollo. Its story is linked with that of neighboring Crater (the cup) and Hydra (the water snake). Dispatched by Apollo to collect water in a cup, the crow returned with neither but with a water snake instead. The constellation is best found by looking southwest of the star Spica in Virgo. One corner of Corvus's rectangle shape is marked by Delta Corvi. This double star consists of a bright 3rd-magnitude blue star orbited by a dimmer star. Corvus contains the Antennae Galaxies, one of the nearest and youngest pairs of colliding galaxies.



Gienah (γ Corvi)
The brightest star in Corvus, this blue-white giant star lies 154 light-years from Earth

KEY DATA

Size ranking	70
Brightest stars	Gienah (γ) 2.6, Beta (β) 2.6
Genitive	Corvi
Abbreviation	Crv
Highest in sky at 10pm	April–May
Fully visible	65°N–90°S



CHART 5



△ NGC 4038 and NGC 4039

The faint tails of stars, gas, and dust that extend from NGC 4038 and NGC 4039 give the galaxies their popular name of the Antennae. The tails formed when the galaxies started to interact a few hundred million years ago. The galaxies' collision led to the creation of huge star-forming regions surrounded by glowing hydrogen gas.